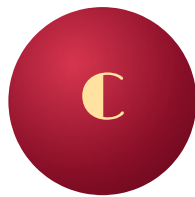


Monte Verde Criminal Police
Case 1114



Envelope C

Lab results and lockers

Keep this envelope sealed. Open it only when Chief Inspector
Duret has answered your call in the game.

7 documents inside, C1 to C7

*For whoever prints this: don't read the pages that follow. Slide them straight into an envelope
with this sheet on top, and seal it.*

Post-mortem examination: Victor Valmont, 67

Cause of death Heart failure caused by acute poisoning with a cardiac glycoside, a heart poison of the foxglove family.

Time of death Between 23:40 and 00:00.

Route By mouth. First symptoms would appear ten to twenty minutes after the first dose.

Findings

- Traces of the poison on the tongue and lips, and on the tips of the right thumb and index finger.
- Stomach: a small amount of cognac. No food since about 20:00.
- Heart healthy for his age. No heart medication prescribed and none in his blood.

Remarks

The pattern of residue, on the fingertips and the tongue, suggests many small doses carried to the mouth by the fingers rather than one poisoned drink.

Toxicology and trace evidence

Item	Result
Solitaire cards from the desk, all 52	Poison on the corners of every card
Cognac glass	Negative
Cognac decanter	Negative
Cigar	Negative. Unlit and untouched.
Fountain pen	Negative
Cellophane wrapper, seal VC-0431	No poison on the outside. No fingerprints at all: wiped clean. The seam carries two lines of glue, the factory's and a second one applied by hand. The pack had been opened and expertly resealed.

The poison

A crude plant extract of *Digitalis purpurea*, the common foxglove. There were no tablet binders or fillers in it, so it was not made from pharmaceutical pills.

For comparison, the digoxin tablets from Dr Kraus's medical bag are a standard pharmaceutical product. They do not match.

The Cage

Deck issue register

Every deck carries a numbered security seal on its cellophane. The numbers are unique and logged when a deck is issued.

Time	Seals	Issued to	Signed
20:00	VC-0429 to VC-0432	Salon Privé, table 1 (4 decks)	T. Grey
20:00	VC-0433 to VC-0448	Blackjack tables 1 to 4 (16 decks)	A. Kovač, J. Ricci
21:55	VC-0917	Crown Office, Mr Valmont's Last Hand	M. Santoro

Midnight count

23:05	Count opened in the Cage by M. Santoro and M. Begić
23:19	Count closed and signed by M. Santoro and M. Begić

Reconciliation at close, 00:40, under police supervision

Station	Issued	Returned	Remarks
Salon Privé, table 1	4	3: VC-0429, VC-0430, VC-0432	VC-0431: "discarded at 21:30, drink spilled on it. T.G." No discarded deck was found in the Salon Privé bins.
Blackjack 1 to 4	16	16	None
Crown Office	1: VC-0917	Not returned	In the office, per procedure

Dealer rotation

Dealer	Dealing	On break
T. Grey	20:30–21:40, 21:55–23:05, 23:20–00:30	21:40–21:55, 23:05–23:20
A. Kovač	Covers table 1 during T. Grey's breaks, otherwise blackjack 2	None

Hand history, final table

Seats: 1 N. Petrov, 2 L. Kraus, 3 H. Duval, 4 K. Okafor, 5 A. Lindqvist. A player who leaves the table is marked as sitting out and is not dealt in. Nobody sat out between 22:45 and 23:52.

Hand	Time	Dealer	Seats dealt in
#38	23:01	T. Grey	1 2 3 4 5
#39	23:04	T. Grey	1 2 3 4 5
#40	23:07	A. Kovač	1 2 3 4 5
#41	23:10	A. Kovač	1 2 3 4 5
#42	23:13	A. Kovač	1 2 3 4 5
#43	23:16	A. Kovač	1 2 3 4 5
#44	23:19	A. Kovač	1 2 3 4 5
#45	23:22	T. Grey	1 2 3 4 5
#46	23:26	T. Grey	1 2 3 4 5
#47	23:29	T. Grey	1 2 3 4 5

Search of staff lockers and dressing rooms, 02:00 to 03:00

No member of staff had left the building since it was sealed at 00:15.

Staff roster: locker numbers

03	Marco Santoro, floor manager
07	Ana Kovač, dealer
12	Luka Petrić, bartender
16	Mirela Begić, cashier
21	Tobias Grey, dealer
24	Jonas Ricci, dealer

What we found

Locker 03

Jacket, cigarettes, and a second, handwritten ledger of “adjustments” to the nightly count, September to November, totalling €40,000.

Locker 07

Street clothes, a paperback novel, hand cream.

Locker 12

Bar knives, a racing paper, a jar of cocktail cherries.

Locker 16

Calculator, lunch box, knitting.

Locker 21

Street clothes. A sealed deck of Velvet Crown cards, seal **VC-0917**, cellophane intact. A white Bauta mask of the kind handed out to guests, folded in a napkin. A pair of thin black gloves. Magician's props: a thumb tip, flash paper, cellophane sheets, a glue pen and a small heat sealer. An empty amber dropper bottle, hand-labelled *Fingerhut*. A faded photograph of a stage magician with a small boy on his shoulders. On the back: *Für Tobi, von deinem Papa, dem Graven Geist. 1999*

Locker 24

Street clothes, a gym bag.

Dressing room A, Mrs Valmont

Gowns. A bundle of love letters signed “N.”

Dressing room B, Ms Moreau

Throat spray. A contract offer from the Aurora Palace: two million for three years. A photograph of a little girl on the shoulders of a man holding a trumpet, marked “Papa, Cirque Lumière, 1998”.

Cloakroom ticket 118, Dr Kraus

Medical bag, searched with his consent: stethoscope, prescription pad, a box of digoxin 0.25 mg tablets prescribed to L. Kraus (30 in the box, 28 left), and a stack of IOUs.

Monte Verde Courier

Friday 12 March 2004

“Grey Ghost” jailed for casino fraud

Velvet Crown’s star illusionist gets six years after the owner’s testimony

Anton Grauer, 44, the Austrian illusionist who packed the Velvet Crown’s cabaret for a decade as the Grey Ghost (*Der Graue Geist*), was sentenced yesterday to six years in prison for cheating at the casino’s high-stakes tables.

The case rested largely on the evidence of casino owner Victor Valmont, who told the court he had

personally watched Grauer switch marked cards into play.

Grauer, famous for his signature illusion, the Vanishing Ring, denied the charges to the end. “I have never cheated at cards,” he told reporters on the court steps. “Only at magic.”

His wife Margit and their son, aged eight, will return to her family in Innsbruck.

Monte Verde Courier, Thursday 3 December 2009

Illusionist dies in prison

Anton Grauer, 49, once celebrated as the Grey Ghost, died of pneumonia on Tuesday in Monte Verde prison, three months before his release. He always maintained his innocence.

**Isabella Valmont***Victor's wife*

A new will? I knew nothing about it. Victor never talked about money with me.

My keycard never left my clutch, I swear it. Well, the clutch left my hand twice. At ten to eleven, during the dealer's ring trick, it lay on the rail right beside him. And when I came back to the Salon Privé at about 23:35, I knocked it off the rail. The same dealer, Tobias, picked it up and handed it back to me. Such lovely hands.

Nikolai and I... yes. Since the summer. That isn't murder.

**Marco Santoro***Floor manager*

All right. I took money from the count. Forty thousand. I meant to put it back before he noticed. But I didn't kill him.

I carried deck VC-0917 up at 22:01, sealed, and I signed for it. I never went back up until midnight. Ask Mirela.

**Dr Leopold Kraus***Victor's physician*

The digoxin is mine, for my own heart. Two tablets gone this week, and both of them are inside me.

Yes, I owe Victor money, and yes, I said something foolish at the bar. But I was dealt into every hand at that table. Check the history.

**Nikolai Petrov***Rival casino owner*

Isabella and I have been close since the summer. That is not a crime in Monte Verde.

I was in every hand from eleven until half past. The table's own records will tell you so. And at my height, Inspector, I am hard to mistake for anyone else.



Celeste Moreau
Resident jazz singer

The Grey Ghost? I've never heard the name. My father played trumpet in a travelling circus band. He died in a road accident when I was nine.

And the poison: everyone backstage knew by half past twelve. Dr Kraus was shouting it down the corridor.



Tobias Grey
Dealer, Salon Privé

Deck 0431? Somebody knocked a gin and tonic over it at half past nine. Wet cards are useless, so I threw them away and noted it. That's procedure.

The terrace. Alone. I needed air.

The photograph in my locker is my father. He was a magician. Lots of people's fathers were something. Grey is my name. It always has been.



Ana Kovač
Relief dealer

I took over the final table at 23:05 and handed it back to Tobias at 23:20 exactly. He came back out of breath and pink in the face. Not like someone who'd been smoking on a terrace. More like someone who'd taken the stairs two at a time.

And a spilled drink at half past nine? Not at that table. I brought the players their drinks myself, and everything was dry.



Mirela Begić
Cashier, the Cage

Marco was in the Cage with me from 23:05 until we signed off the count at 23:19. He never left. There's a camera over the Cage door if you want to check.

Officer's note: camera 02 confirms it.



Luka Petrić
Bartender, Le Trèfle

The doctor and Mr Valmont had words at my bar around half past ten. The doctor said something like, "You'll get your money over my dead body, or yours." Then he stormed off to the Salon Privé.